Chapter - 4 Suggestibility

Suggestibility is a

fundamental concept in hypnosis, reflecting the degree to which an individual is responsive to suggestions. Understanding the relationship between suggestibility and hypnosis can shed light on how hypnotherapy and hypnotic techniques work. Suggestibility is very important in hypnosis because it affects how well a person can enter a hypnotic state and respond to suggestions. When someone is more suggestible, they can more easily relax and focus during hypnosis, making it easier for the hypnotist to guide them. This makes the hypnosis session more effective, especially for therapeutic purposes like reducing anxiety, quitting smoking, or changing other behaviours. People who are highly suggestible tend to trust the hypnotist and the process more, which helps them to follow suggestions and achieve better results. Understanding a person's level of suggestibility also helps the hypnotist to tailor their approach, ensuring that the session is as effective as possible.

Types of Suggestibility

Based on the context in which suggestions are made and the individual's responsiveness, suggestibility can be categorized, each playing a unique role in how individuals accept and act upon suggestions. In hypnosis, physical suggestibility and emotional suggestibility are two different types of responsiveness to hypnotic suggestions

**based on their predominant
response styles—either physical or emotional. These concepts help hypnotists modify their
approach to the individual's natural tendencies.**

Physical Suggestibility

**Physical suggestibility refers to a person's tendency to respond to suggestions that
involve physical sensations and motor activities. Individuals with high physical suggestibility are more likely to respond to direct, literal, and sensory-based suggestions. They often show noticeable physical reactions to hypnotic suggestions.**

Characteristics and Examples:

**- Direct and Literal Suggestions: Physically suggestible individuals respond well to straightforward suggestions like "Your arm is getting lighter" or "You feel a warm
sensation in your hand."**

- Sensory Focus:

**These individuals are more affected by suggestions involving
physical sensations, such as feeling warmth, heaviness, or tingling.**

- Observable Reactions:

They may exhibit visible physical responses, such as moving an arm, closing eyes, or relaxing muscles.

Example:

If a hypnotist suggests that the person's hand is stuck to a table, a physically suggestible person might genuinely feel as if their hand cannot move and show physical signs of struggling to lift it.

Emotional Suggestibility

Emotional suggestibility refers to a person's tendency to respond to suggestions that involve emotions, feelings, and abstract concepts. Individuals with high emotional suggestibility are more likely to respond to indirect, metaphorical, and emotionally charged suggestions. They often exhibit subtle, internalized reactions to hypnotic suggestions.

Characteristics and Examples:

- Indirect and Metaphorical Suggestions:

Emotionally suggestible individuals respond better to suggestions that are abstract or emotional, such as "Imagine a wave of calmness washing over you" or "You feel a deep sense of peace."

- Emotional Focus: **These individuals are more affected by suggestions involving emotions and feelings, such as feeling more confident, happy, or relaxed.**

Delicate Reactions: **Their responses might be more internal and less visible, such as a change in mood or emotional state.**

Example: **If a hypnotist suggests that the person feels a growing sense of inner peace, an emotionally suggestible person might experience a profound sense of calm and emotional relief, even though there may not be any noticeable physical changes.**

Somnambulism

A somnambulist, in the context of hypnosis, refers to a person who exhibits a high degree of hypnotic suggestibility and responsiveness. This type will respond equally well to all suggestions, both direct and inferred, affecting both the body and the emotions. These individuals are often able to enter deep states of hypnosis quickly and readily accept and act upon suggestions from the hypnotist.

Characteristics and Examples:

-High Suggestibility: **Somnambulists are highly responsive to hypnotic suggestions. They can easily enter deep hypnotic states.**

-Absorption: **They have a heightened ability to concentrate and focus inwardly during hypnosis. This absorption allows them to vividly imagine scenarios suggested
by the hypnotist and experience them as real.**

-Amnesia: **Somnambulists may experience selective amnesia during hypnosis, where they forget certain suggestions or experiences after emerging from the hypnotic state.**

-Physical Responses: **They may exhibit physical responses to suggestions, such as changes in muscle tone, temperature perception, or other physical sensations suggested by the hypnotist.**

Example:
Imagine a hypnotherapist working with a client who wants to overcome a fear of public speaking. During the induction phase the hypnotherapist suggests that the client feels confident, calm, and in control whenever they imagine themselves speaking in front of others. The somnambulist not only visualizes this scenario vividly but also experiences a sense of relaxation and confidence deep within.

Intellectual suggestibility

Intellectual suggestibility refers to a person's tendency to respond to suggestions based on cognitive reasoning and intellectual understanding. Individuals high in intellectual suggestibility often analyse suggestions critically and may require logical explanations or justifications before accepting them.

Characteristics and Examples:

Analytical Thinking: **Individuals with intellectual suggestibility tend to evaluate the logic, coherence, and reasoning behind suggestions before accepting them.**

-Need for Explanation: **They often require clear explanations or justifications for the suggestions provided during hypnosis.**

-Preference for Rationality: **Intellectual suggestible rely on rationality and logic to assess the validity and effectiveness of suggestions. They may engage in a process of reasoning and evaluation before deciding to adopt a suggestion.**

-Open to Logical Arguments: **They are more receptive to suggestions that are backed by evidence or reasoned explanations.**

Example:

Imagine a hypnotherapist working with a client who wants to overcome a fear of flying. The client, who exhibits high intellectual suggestibility, engages in a detailed discussion with the hypnotherapist about the safety measures in place on modern aircraft, statistical safety records, and the principles of aerodynamics. During the hypnosis session, the hypnotherapist carefully explains how the subconscious mind can be reassured through positive suggestions about flying safety, backed by logical reasoning and evidence-based information.

How Suggestibility is learned?

Suggestibility is influenced by a combination of innate tendencies and learned experiences.
While some aspects of suggestibility might be inherent, many factors that shape suggestibility are acquired through personal experiences, social interactions, and environmental influences. Here's a detailed look at how suggestibility is learned.

Innate Tendencies

1. Temperament: Some people are naturally more open to suggestions due to their temperament. Those who are more agreeable or empathetic may inherently be more suggestible.
2. Genetics: There may be a genetic component that influences individuals to higher or lower levels of suggestibility, although this is still an area of ongoing research.

Learned Experiences

1. Early Childhood:
Parental Influence: Children learn suggestibility from their parents and caregivers.
A child who is often reassured and whose feelings are validated may grow up to be more emotionally suggestible.
Environment: A stable, supportive environment can lead to higher emotional suggestibility, while a more challenging or unpredictable environment might foster lower suggestibility or a more physically based response to suggestions.

2. Education and Socialization:
School and Peer Interactions: Teachers, peers, and school experiences play a significant role in shaping suggestibility. Positive reinforcement from authority figures can enhance suggestibility.
Social Dynamics: Individuals learn to be more or less suggestible based on their social interactions. Peer pressure and social conformity can increase suggestibility

3. Cultural Factors:
Cultural Norms: Cultures that value collectivism and conformity may foster higher suggestibility, while cultures that value individualism and scepticism may foster lower suggestibility.
Media Influence: Exposure to media and societal norms can shape suggestibility by consistently presenting certain ideas and behaviours as desirable or acceptable.

4. Personal Experiences:
Traumatic Experiences: Trauma can alter suggestibility. For example, individuals who have experienced significant trauma may become more suggestible to certain triggers or protective suggestions.
Positive Reinforcement: Experiences where suggestions led to positive outcomes can reinforce suggestibility. For example, if a suggestion to try a new activity leads to enjoyment and success, the person may become more open to future suggestions.

Psychological and Cognitive Factors

1. Self-Esteem: People with lower self-esteem might be more suggestible as they may rely more on external validation and guidance.
2. Cognitive Development: As people grow and their cognitive abilities develop, their level of critical thinking and distrust can influence their suggestibility. Children and adolescents are generally more suggestible than adults.
3. Hypnotisability: Some individuals have a higher natural capacity for hypnosis,

which can indicate higher general suggestibility. This trait can be enhanced or diminished through practice and experience.

Examples of How Suggestibility is Learned

1. In the Family:
Scenario: A child grows up in a household where parents frequently use positive reinforcement.
Outcome: The child learns to trust and follow suggestions from authority figures, developing higher emotional suggestibility.
2. In Education:
Scenario: A student is praised by a teacher for following instructions carefully and
performing well on assignments.
Outcome: The student learns that accepting and acting on suggestions leads to positive outcomes, reinforcing suggestibility.

3. In Social Settings:
Scenario: A teenager joins a peer group where conformity is valued and rewarded.
Outcome: The teenager learns to be more suggestible to peer influences to gain acceptance and approval.

4. Through Media:
Scenario: An individual watches a lot of advertisements that use emotional appeals.
Outcome: The individual learns to associate certain products with positive emotions, increasing suggestibility to advertising.

Strategies for Understanding and Working with Suggestibility

1) Modifying Communication: By understanding someone's background and experiences, you can adjust your suggestions to better suit how they think and respond. This makes it easier for them to accept and follow your suggestions.
2) Building Trust: When you build a trusting relationship with someone, they

feel safe
and are more likely to be open to your suggestions. Trust makes them more comfortable and willing to listen to you.

3) Providing Positive Reinforcement: When you praise or reward someone for responding well to a suggestion, it encourages them to continue accepting suggestions in the future. Positive feedback makes them feel good about their progress.

4) Encouraging Critical Thinking: Teaching people to think carefully and critically
helps them evaluate suggestions better. This way, they can choose to accept only those suggestions that are beneficial and make sense to them, leading to better outcomes.
By recognizing the factors that contribute to learned suggestibility, one can better
understand and effectively interact with individuals according to their suggestibility
type.

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